GLASSHOUSE

FESTIVE CHEER

Diwali may be a few moons away, but **Rahul Gandhi** is already bringing some festive cheer in Uttar Pradesh. At an election rally back in May, the Congress leader had visited barber Mithun's humble salon in Lalganj in his Lok Sabha constituency Raebareli for a quick trim. Fast forward four months and, voila! Congress workers show up with a "thank you" package: three snazzy barber chairs, and even an inverter battery to power up Mithun's business. The gifts didn't stop there. Rahul had also made a pit stop at cobbler Ramchet's shop in Sultanpur in July where he had channelled his inner craftsman to fix a sole and received a pair of handmade shoes as gift. Now, Ramchet has got a return gift: a shoe-stitching machine and a few other tools of the trade. The Raebareli MP sure knows how to look after his UP brethren.



Illustrations by SIDDHANT JUMDE



Traffic Trans Formation

Telangana CM **A. Revanth Reddy** is nothing if not creative—especially when it comes to "transforming Hyderabad into a future city". His latest brainwave? On September 12, he proposed enlisting transpeople to manage the city traffic, much like the home guards do. They will be given uniforms, training and a monthly stipend. Reddy is apparently a big believer in promoting social justice for the third gender. Critics complain that many of the people he's championing are already on the streets, hustling commuters at traffic signals. But then that may be the point—turning the street hustle into a path for empowerment.

Kaushik Deka with Ashish Misra, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar, Pradip R. Sagar and Amarnath K. Menon

THE RENAME GAMES

It seems like **Naveen Patnaik's** Biju Janata Dal is never short of ammo as it rains fire on the new BJP-led Odisha government. Union education minister and BJP leader Dharmendra Pradhan was the first to run for cover after suggesting a name change for Ravenshaw University. Then the state renamed a scheme of the previous government, the Mo School Abhiyan, launched in 2017 to improve government schools. It will now be called Panchasakha Sikhya Setu, to honour the famous five medieval saints of Odisha (which the BJD says is no honour at all). The latest fire is over the state government shutting down schools and colleges in Bhubaneswar for **Prime Minister Narendra Modi's** visit to the state on September 17, his birthday.





GALWAN GETAWAY



It looks like army chief **Gen. Upendra Dwivedi** is a Hindi film buff, given the *Main Hoon Na* reference he threw in while inviting countrymen to visit India's remote border areas. The army has now opened up access to some of our icy battlegrounds—places like Galwan and Rezang la—where history was forged in sub-zero temperatures. And in true *filmi* style, Dwivedi assured visitors that even if the locals aren't around, the Indian Army would always be there to greet them, just like Shah Rukh Khan in the Bollywood blockbuster.

A Steely Silence

The fight against the privatisation of Visakhapatnam Steel Plant has everyone, from workers to concerned citizens, up in arms except, it seems, Andhra Pradesh chief minister **N. Chandrababu Naidu.** His lukewarm lobbying for the plant's survival has people wondering if he has forgotten it exists. Meanwhile, the rival YSR Congress Party is cranking up the volume, calling for the resignation of TDP legislators to armtwist Naidu and get a firm commitment from New Delhi. Steel workers, already jittery over raw material being withheld, fear the plant's shutdown is a done deal. While local TDP chief P. Srinivasa Rao is ready to quit in protest, Naidu remains tight-lipped. Maybe the focus on raising the new capital Amaravati has bogged him down—or is it that the 'double engine sarkar' has run out of steam?

